

S04-04 - The Keystone Reveal

Player text

The Custodian unfolds her home like a blossoming flower and draws the crate inside, sealing it open again as a workshop. She breaks the seal. Inside lies a massive stone carved with a lion's face. She goes still, then nods, slow and grave. "Of course Emeris would keep this delivery quiet," she says. "This is the Keystone Asset: the heart-stone for Hush's failing ward. If the route knew what you carried, every hungry thing in the preserve would follow the scent of it." The light in her home dims as she speaks. "We must take it to the Open Vale and revitalize the ward before Hush has to trust paper promises instead of protection. That much magic will draw dangerous things from the deep preserve. I will need your help."

Public objective

Learn what the package is and what must be done.

Raw source

- Id: S04-04
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-FOUR
- Sectiontitle: Act Four: The Hanging Office
- Title: The Keystone Reveal
- Shorttitle: Keystone Reveal
- Order: 504
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S04-04-the-keystone-reveal.png
- Alt: The Keystone Reveal scene art for The Hanging Office.
- Caption: The Keystone Asset stops being cargo and becomes a communal protection problem.
- Mood: The Hanging Office
- Gmgoal: Route the package reveal through the Custodian, not Marlowe, and set keystone_understanding.
- Publicobjective: Learn what the package is and what must be done.
- Readaloud: The Custodian unfolds her home like a blossoming flower and draws the crate inside, sealing it open again as a workshop. She breaks the seal. Inside lies a massive stone carved with a lion's face. She goes still, then nods, slow and grave. "Of course Emeris would keep this delivery quiet," she says. "This is the Keystone Asset: the heart-stone for Hush's failing ward. If the route knew what you carried, every hungry thing in the preserve would follow the scent of it." The light in her home dims as she speaks. "We must take it to the Open Vale and revitalize the ward before Hush has to trust paper promises instead of protection. That much magic will draw dangerous things from the deep preserve. I will need your help."
- Gmnotes: This is the controlled spoiler release. Earlier player text must not have named the Keystone Asset. Players can react before choosing prep. Do not rush the

table out of shock.

- Gmscript: Say: "The Custodian carries this reveal. Marlowe can recognize a personal detail if she is present, but the truth does not depend on any one PC."
- Gmreadaloud: She breaks the seal. Inside lies a massive stone carved with a lion's face. "This is the Keystone Asset: the heart-stone for Hush's failing ward."
- Gmchecklist: Check package_status before starting; if lost, do not run this reveal as written. Name Keystone Asset here for the first time in player text. Route recognition through the Custodian. Marlowe gets only an optional bonus recognition beat. Set keystone_understanding surface/deep. Seed, but do not explain, the deeper consume/soul-economy truth.
- Gmprivate: If package_status=lost, stop the normal reveal and use only the Kyle-confirmed recovery branch when it exists. The deepest truth is that the ward protects by consuming. In Act 4 this remains a seed, never a full explanation. Calibrate her candor to custodian_trust and ward_awareness.
- Playertakeaway: The job was never small, and now you know why: you are being asked to finish it at real risk.
- Storytakeaway: The package was the heart-stone for Hush's failing ward, and renewing it will draw danger from the deep preserve.
- Mechanictakeaway: The reveal writes keystone_understanding: surface from hearing her, deep from Knowledge 14 or hard questions with high trust.
- Rollcards: s04-04-recognize-the-keystone S04-04 Recognize the Keystone Recognize the Keystone Knowledge Knowledge None 12 Knowledge connects heraldry, wardcraft, and custody. The party carries a capital crisis without understanding it. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The party carries a capital crisis without understanding it. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs time, noise, leverage...
- Entityids: keystone-asset marlowe-fairwind whitefire-custodian emeris-crown-holdings goldspire-territories open-vale-ward-lines ward-stability-track sealed-keystone-crate dustless-ward-map ward-renewal-chime difficulty-ladder stress hush fear
- Entities: keystone-asset Keystone Asset? item Item / Asset assets/icons/item.png assets/item-images/keystone-asset/profile_base.png KEE-stohn ASS-et Inside the sealed crate, packed in wax-paper and reassurance, sits a heavy grey stone the size of a loaf, warm to the touch, faintly humming, with a light deep inside it that is slowly going out. Keystone Asset?, Emeris Crown Holdings: the ward-stone that keeps Emeris safe. It is failing and must be renewed at Open Vale. The Hidden Contents Do not show this image during the Prologue. Use the sealed package instead. A massive ward-stone from the capital gate, needed to renew protective infrastructure.; use Keystone Asset as a concrete table object with texture, ownership, and a reason it matters now. Give players a tangible handle on Marlowe Fairwind, Whitefire

Custodian, Open Vale? Ritual Site, whether they inspect, carry, return, trade, or refuse it. A massive ward-stone from the capital gate, needed to renew protective infrastructure. marlowe-fairwind Marlowe Fairwind pc PC / Player Character assets/icons/type-pc.png assets/entities/marlowe-fairwind.png MAR-low FAIR-wind A playable pregen character and the default package custodian. Marlowe...

- Factionids: emeris-crown-holdings
- Locationids: goldspire-territories open-vale-ward-lines
- Itemids: keystone-asset whitefire-ward-charm
- Clueids: public-private-ward-compact dustless-ward-map the-pre-dated-invoice the-convenient-renewal the-ward-subscription the-cheerful-ledger
- Worldconnectionprompts: S04-04-emeris-crown-holdings-world-connection emeris-crown-holdings Emeris Crown Holdings You have worked a job like this before. What is the part of the contract you learned to read twice?
- Statecontrols: custodian_trust Custodian Trust select low neutral high ritual_prep Ritual Prep select unready ready keystone_understanding Keystone Understanding select surface deep package_status Package Status select held lost ward_awareness Ward Awareness select none seed aware
- Mechanicids: knowledge instinct critical-success presence hope fear table-spotlight
- Playerquestions: What is your first reaction when the stone is named? Do you inspect it, question her, or just absorb what this means? Who says yes first, and who hesitates?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in The Keystone Reveal that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to expose neglected infrastructure, stress the Custodian, or make the Keystone hum at the wrong moment. Make neglected infrastructure answer at the wrong moment. Stress the Custodian's trust without turning her into a device.
- Choicesconsequences: Hear the Custodian's reveal The party learns the package is the heart-stone for Hush's failing ward. Set keystone_understanding=surface. S04-05 prep starts with honest stakes. keystone_understanding surface benefit and dread player-visible Inspect the stone closely The character senses old, high-tier ward magic and a draining quality. Knowledge 14 can set keystone_understanding=deep. S04-05 and Act 5 begin with stronger dread and better prep. keystone_understanding deep both spoiler-gated Press the Custodian with high trust She admits she is uneasy about what the ward draws on, without explaining the full truth. custodian_trust high + ward_awareness aware unlocks a deeper seed. The soul-economy thread is seeded for later without being resolved. keystone_understanding deep possible both GM-gated/player-safe seed Arrive without the package The normal reveal cannot occur because there is no stone to open. package_status=lost blocks this scene as written. Kyle must confirm the recovery branch before the reveal resolves. package_status lost blocked canon GM-only
- Lootclues: Keystone handling instructions Ward map copy Keystone Asset?: Inside the sealed crate, packed in wax-paper and reassurance, sits a heavy grey stone the size of a loaf, warm to the touch, faintly humming, with a light deep inside it that is slowly going out. Whitefire Custodian's Ward-Charm: A small hand-carved wooden ratcoon mid-scramper has been thumb-worn smooth for luck. It is warm, and the forest feels a little kinder while you hold it.

- Handouts: Keystone pulse Guaranteed seed Earned seed
- Sources: S04-04-the-keystone-reveal
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act4_Upgrade_Packet/ACT4_SCENE_RESEARCH.md
dist/Act4_Upgrade_Packet/ACT4_OPEN_QUESTIONS.md
- References: Toward Open Vale #S04-05 Hanging Office map #MAP-LOC-the-hanging-office
Open Questions sources/Act4_Upgrade_Packet/ACT4_OPEN_QUESTIONS.md
- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. The sealed package is the capital's ward Keystone; the city is unwarded while it is away. KEEP GUARANTEED "The wood never needed managing. It needed leaving alone." ADD SEED "Your capital's safety is older than your contracts. It is the very thing they teach you to fear." ADD SEED The Keystone's magic is pre-corporate forest-ward work, the same school companies call primitive. ADD EARNED Knowledge Hard 20 The Custodian glances at obsolete Soulsfire inspection seals on her counterweight boulder. ADD EARNED Instinct Medium 15 The sealed package is the capital's ward Keystone; the city is unwarded while it is away. KEEP GUARANTEED "Your capital's safety is older than your contracts. It is the very thing they teach you to fear." ADD SEED The Keystone's magic is pre-corporate forest-ward work, the same school companies call primitive. ADD EARNED Knowledge Hard 20 Presence: earn candor. Knowledge...
- Livetools: scene MAP-LOC-goldspire-territories MAP-LOC-open-vale-ward-lines
- Percharacterlayer: marlowe-fairwind Marlowe Fairwind Bonus recognition If present, Marlowe recognizes the lion-faced stone from the capital's archway. This is bonus flavor only. Knowledge 14 May sense the stone drains to ward, setting keystone_understanding=deep. The Custodian still carries the reveal. Can personalize the recognition without making the plot depend on her. Marlowe, you have seen this stone before, over the capital's archway. Want to say where it is from? garrick-reed Garrick Reed Operational secrecy Understands why the delivery was secret: an unwarded city is a target. Can spell out the stakes in plain protective language. Garrick, you get why this was hush-hush. An unguarded city is a kill-box. Want to spell out the stakes? varian-soto Varian Soto Same strange life The stone feels like the trees and moss: all one strange living system. Can voice unease without knowing the full cost. Varian, the stone feels like the trees and the moss: all the same strange life. Want to voice that unease? khari-nix Khari Nix City weight Feels the guardian weight of a whole city's safety in one stone. Can name the moral weight of accepting the next risk. Khari, a city's survival is in one stone, in...
- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway The job was never small, and now you know why. "This is the moment the stakes get honest. Hush safety is in this room, and she is asking you to go further." "React. Ask her what it is, why it was hidden, what the ritual costs, or just take a breath and decide how you feel." Pause here. Do not push past the reveal until players have had space to react. knowledge presence table-spotlight Story takeaway The package was the heart-stone for Hush's survival. "You were not courrying cargo. You were carrying the thing Hush needs before its protection fails." "Surface truth: it renews Hush's ward, it is dangerous to move openly, and secrecy keeps the route from becoming a feeding trail." Deeper truth stays gated: it drains or consumes something. Seed only on deep inspection/high trust. knowledge presence table-spotlight Mechanic takeaway The reveal writes keystone_understanding.

"If you want to know more, examine the stone or press her. What you learn shapes how ready you are for what is next." "Knowledge 14: the stone is old, high-tier wardcraft, and draining. Set keystone_understanding=deep. Otherwise set surface." Marlowe can personalize the recognition, but the...

- Playerbeats: S04-04-workshop Workshop unfolds The unfolding workshop assets/scenes/S04-04-the-keystone-reveal.png The Keystone Reveal scene art for The Hanging Office. The home opens wider than it should and draws the crate inside. The home opens wider than it should and draws the crate inside. The home opens wider than it should and draws the crate inside. image-title-caption S04-04-stone Lion-faced stone The Keystone Asset assets/scenes/S04-04-the-keystone-reveal.png The Keystone Reveal scene art for The Hanging Office. The seal breaks. Inside is a massive lion-faced stone. The Custodian recognizes it and names it as the heart-stone for Hush's failing ward. The seal breaks. Inside is a massive lion-faced stone. The Custodian recognizes it and names it as the heart-stone for Hush's failing ward. The seal breaks. Inside is a massive lion-faced stone. The Custodian recognizes it and names it as the heart-stone for Hush's failing ward. text-first S04-04-ask The ask The Open Vale ask assets/scenes/S04-04-the-keystone-reveal.png The Keystone Reveal scene art for The Hanging Office. She says the stone must be renewed at the Open Vale, and the magic will draw dangerous things from the deep...
- Gmbeats: S04-04-workshop Workshop unfolds The unfolding workshop Say: "Her home unfolds like it has been waiting for this exact crate." The home opens wider than it should and draws the crate inside. The treehouse becomes the reveal chamber. Let the table watch before naming the truth. Players know the handoff has become ritual space. Player takeaway Players know the handoff has become ritual space. "Her home unfolds like it has been waiting for this exact crate." "The playable fact is: The home opens wider than it should and draws the crate inside." Concrete actions for this beat: look closely, ask the Custodian a direct question, commit to a choice, or take one prep action. table-spotlight Story takeaway The treehouse becomes the reveal chamber. "Her home unfolds like it has been waiting for this exact crate." "The story fact in play is: The treehouse becomes the reveal chamber." This beat changes Act 4 through this exact pressure: The treehouse becomes the reveal chamber. table-spotlight Mechanic takeaway Let the table watch before naming the truth. "Her home unfolds like it has been waiting for this exact crate." "The active procedure is: Let the table watch before naming the..."
- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 8500
- Playersafeprojection: S04-04 scene The Keystone Reveal assets/scenes/S04-04-the-keystone-reveal.png The Keystone Reveal scene art for The Hanging Office. The Keystone Asset stops being cargo and becomes a communal protection problem. The Hanging Office Learn what the package is and what must be done. The Custodian unfolds her home like a blossoming flower and draws the crate inside, sealing it open again as a workshop. She breaks the seal. Inside lies a massive stone carved with a lion's face. She goes still, then nods, slow and grave. "Of course Emeris would keep this delivery quiet," she says. "This is the Keystone Asset: the heart-stone for Hush's failing ward. If the route knew what you carried, every hungry thing in the preserve would follow the scent of it." The light in her home dims as she speaks. "We must take it to the Open Vale and revitalize the ward before Hush

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- Companionmaps: MAP-LOC-goldspire-territories MAP-LOC-open-vale-ward-lines
- Slidenumber: 58
- Totalslides: 110

Export Stamp

Build 2026-07-05T12:33:16 | Content hash 3011255a4b1b89c7 | Source hash 6753a06c32e5dca07a19eb73